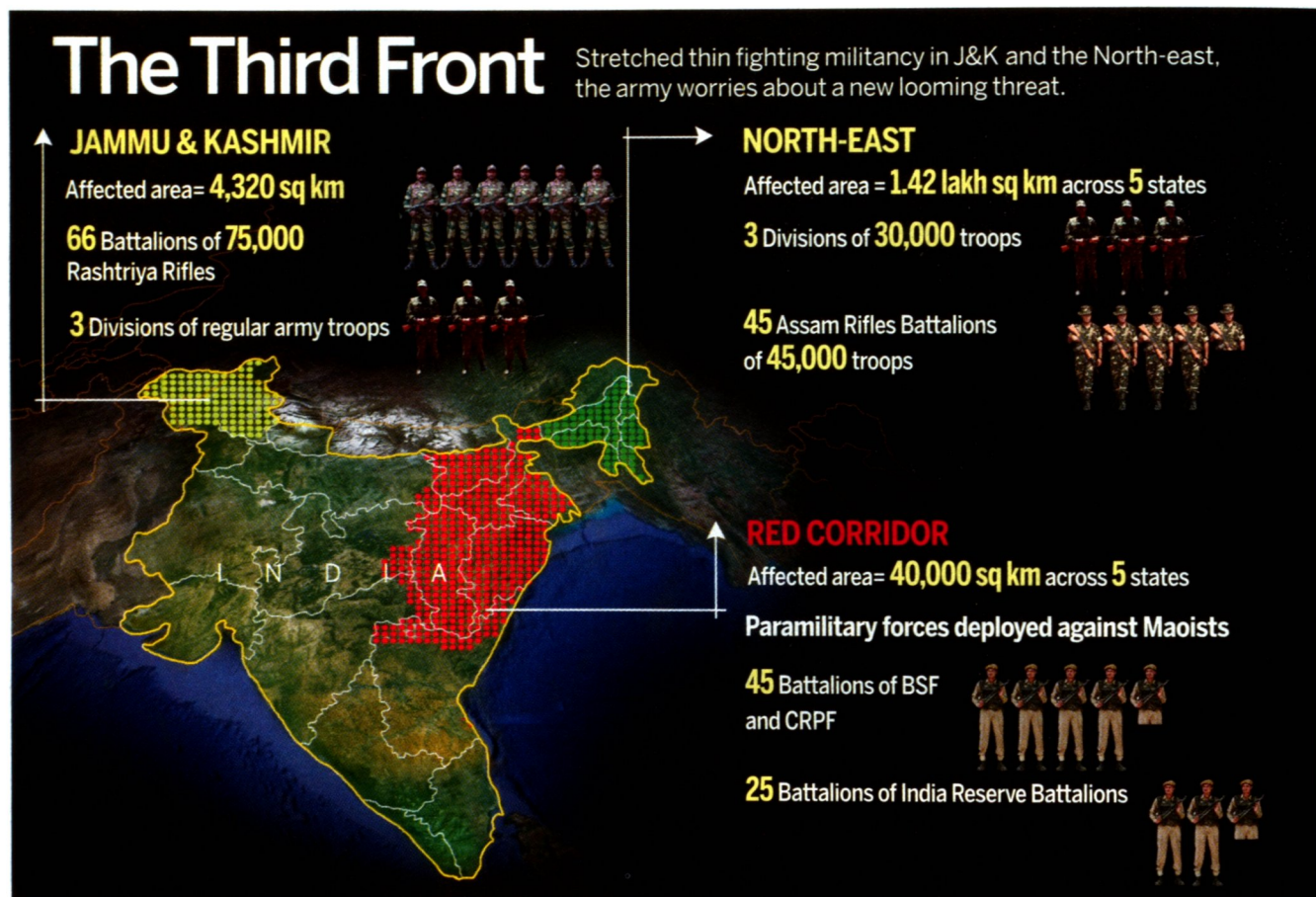


even personnel from the tiny Sashastra Seema Bal into areas like Chhattisgarh and Orissa, which have witnessed a spurt in Maoist violence. But after these deployments, the game will be up. The Home Ministry will be hard pressed to redeploy forces without leaving the vacated areas vulnerable, senior security officials admit.

Military analysts argue for an im-

Deploying the army without the Armed Forces Special Powers Act (AFSPA)—which gives it the power to arrest and detain—will be ineffective. The AFSPA has proved extremely controversial in the north and North-east. “To use AFSPA will mean having to first declare large swathes of the country as disturbed areas. Will so many state assemblies vote in favour of this?” asks former

quiet J&K and North-east would allow it to refocus on honing its capabilities for a two-front war with China and Pakistan knows there will no quick victories against the highly motivated Maoists. Back-of-the-envelope calculations show that it could eventually take the equivalent of nearly two army corps comprising four or more divisions of over 60,000 soldiers to bring order into



Map not to scale

Graphic by PRASHANT CHAUDHARY / www.indiatodayimages.com

mediate deployment of the army as fire-fighting force. “It is important to break the momentum generated by the Maoists and bring them into the national mainstream,” says Major-General G.D. Bakshi, who commanded an RR division in J&K.

It is still unclear in what capacity the Centre intends to use the army—in a support role, as a deterrent or as a spearhead. The positives of deploying a highly trained force with organic logistics and improvised explosive device detecting capabilities could be rapidly overshadowed by the negatives.

Intelligence Bureau chief Ajit Doval.

In Operation Steeplechase in 1971, the army swiftly crushed the Naxal insurrection in West Bengal that was admittedly high on idealism and low on military tactics. Against a highly motivated Liberation Tigers of Tamil Eelam, the Indian Peace Keeping Force lost over 1,000 personnel before withdrawing in ignominy two years later. The army's other deployments in counter-insurgency from the North-east and Punjab to J&K have been slow and laborious grinds lasting decades.

The army, which reasoned that a

the entire Red Corridor. Far more than the single division of RR troops the army is presently willing to spare.

Another reason the Indian Army is reluctant to deploy is because the Maoist problem is a ‘heartland insurgency’ which will suck troops far away from the borders as opposed to a ‘rimland insurgency’ which is closer to disputed borders with China or Pakistan. “It won’t be very different from a quagmire like Waziristan which has drawn in a third of the Pakistan army,” says a senior army official. In South Block, the countdown has begun.